Best property manager in Crested Butte and Leadville? Here is the data behind the claim

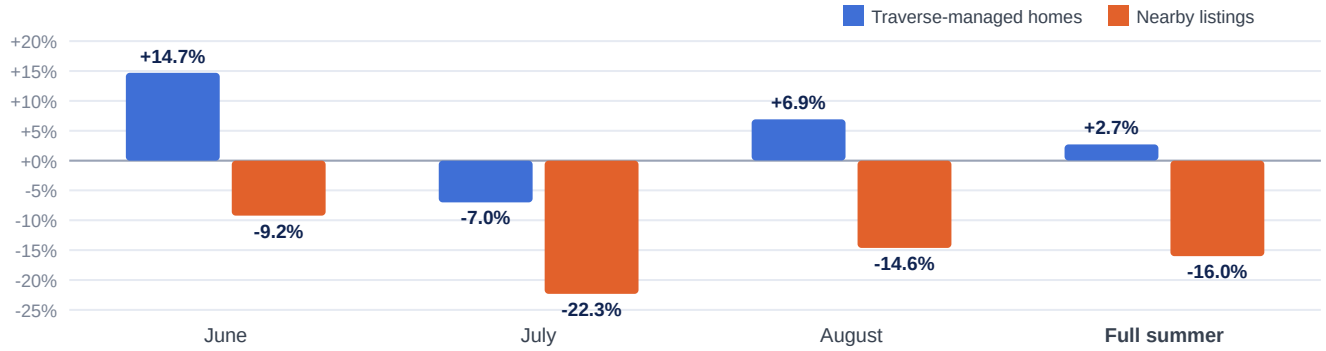
An explainer for owners comparing property managers in Colorado's mountain markets. Every number below is from a named source and a stated date; the last section explains where each one came from.

The result: up 2.7% while nearby listings fell 16%

In summer 2026 (June–August), Traverse-managed Colorado mountain homes earned 2.7% more revenue per available night than the summer before. The nearby competing listings PriceLabs tracks for those same homes earned 16.0% less. That is a 19-point gap in a season where the market shrank.

SUMMER 2026 VS SUMMER 2025	TRAVERSE-MANAGED HOMES	NEARBY COMPETING LISTINGS
Revenue per available night	**+2.7%**	**−16.0%**
Average nightly rate	**+7.0%**	≈ −5%
Occupancy	71.4% (−2.9 pts)	≈ 61%
Homes ahead / at par / behind their comp set	51 / 19 / 12	—

Revenue per available night, change vs summer 2025, by month



The gap held in all three months. Occupancy stayed 6–14 points above the comp sets every month (69.5% / 71.1% / 73.6% vs 58% / 65% / 61%). None of it is one trick. It is five things done at the same time, most of which a single owner cannot do alone.

1. Revenue management: 150+ pricing decisions a day, and the structure underneath them

Since May 12, 2026 a dedicated revenue manager has run pricing for every Traverse home in PriceLabs. From mid-May through late August that desk made roughly 10,000 pricing actions, about 150 a day in the first month and 100–110 a day through the summer. In September, with ski season being priced, the PriceLabs log shows 7,025 actions in 29 days — about 240 a day. Each action is a rate, a minimum-stay rule or a floor on a specific date range for a specific home.

The visible activity is not the main lever. The larger gains come from the layer nobody sees: base rates, minimum prices, seasonal profiles, gap-night and orphan-day rules, and last-minute discount curves set per home and revised as the season moves. A self-managed listing usually has one nightly rate, a weekend bump, and a smart-pricing toggle. A Traverse home has a pricing model.

What that produced, same homes, same dates, 2026 vs 2025 (May 12 – August 26, 138 homes with a full prior year):

MEASURE	CHANGE VS 2025
Revenue per home	**+47%**
Average nightly rate	**+19%**
Nights booked per home	**+24%**
Bookings per day, portfolio-wide	15 → 34

The same homes were running 18% *below* the prior year from January to May 11, before the change. That is the part most owners never see in a marketing claim: the comparison against what the same homes did with the old approach, not just against the market. Rate and volume moved together — the +19% in nightly rate is the check that the extra nights were not bought with discounts.

2. Distribution: old-school and new-age channels, working at once

A Traverse home is for sale in five places at once, priced and synced from one calendar. About a third of 2026 rental revenue has come from outside Airbnb, and the newest channel — the Expedia group — went from zero to $328K in its first year, including one in five Crested Butte dollars.

CHANNEL	SHARE OF 2026 RENTS (JAN–SEP)	WHY IT MATTERS
Airbnb	64%	Largest audience; Guest Favorite badge drives occupancy (section 3)
VRBO	16%	Families and longer stays; higher revenue per booking
Expedia group	8%	New in 2026; hotel-shoppers who never open Airbnb; 9-day lead times fill gaps
Direct (booktraverse.com)	8%	No platform fee; repeat guests and groups
Booking.com	4%	International and last-minute demand

Old school: the hotel channels. Expedia, Hotels.com, Booking.com, Orbitz and Travelocity were built for hotels, and most vacation-rental owners never list there because the setup is hotel-grade: rate plans, content scores, cancellation policies and a connected channel manager. Traverse's homes appear on them the way a hotel does, and the hotel-shopper who never opens Airbnb books them. That is how the Expedia group went from zero to $328K in its first year and 21% of Crested Butte rents, with 9-day lead times that fill gaps the rental platforms leave open.

New age: the rental platforms. Airbnb, VRBO and last-minute marketplaces such as Whimstay, plus a direct-booking site with its own reviews and a returning-guest list. These rank on different signals — badges, response time, review recency, price competitiveness — so each listing is written and tuned for its platform. All channels run from one synced calendar and one pricing model, so a rate change at 7 a.m. reaches every channel by 7:05.

Most self-managed homes are on one platform, sometimes two, with calendars kept in sync by hand. Every channel a home is not on is a set of guests who will book the home next door.

3. Listings built to rank: 58% Guest Favorites, and the 10-point occupancy gap behind the badge

110 of Traverse's 191 live Airbnb listings carry the Guest Favorite badge (57.6%). The badge requires a sustained 4.90+ rating, at least five recent reviews and a host cancellation rate under 1% — it is earned by operations, not by copywriting.

Inside the portfolio, the badge is worth about 10 points of occupancy at the same nightly rate:

AIRBNB LISTINGS, JULY 2026	HOMES	OCCUPANCY	NIGHTLY RATE	RATING
Guest Favorite	106	**80.8%**	$197	4.90
Not (yet) Guest Favorite	75	70.9%	$195	4.79

The rate is identical. The entire difference is that badged homes get shown more and booked more. The portfolio-wide rating is 4.88.

What goes into each listing:

- Professional photography and a title written for search, not for the owner ("Sauna | 14ft Loft | Mtn Views | Walk Downtown" outperforms "Cozy mountain condo").
- Description, amenities and house rules rewritten per platform, since Airbnb, VRBO and Expedia rank on different fields.
- A review-request sequence after every stay, because five recent reviews is a hard floor for the badge.
- Quarterly audit of every listing without the badge, grouped by what is actually blocking it — review count, a rating a few hundredths short, or a real guest-experience issue that goes to operations.

A self-managed listing is usually written once. A Traverse listing is a working file.

4. Operations: local teams in each town, because the rating is set at the door

Every number above rests on the guest's first ten minutes in the home. Traverse has an in-house maintenance team and dedicated cleaning crews in Leadville and Crested Butte, run by its own cleaning manager rather than booked through a third-party service, with a general manager in each market, a guest-experience lead, and a maintenance lead who handles same-day fixes.

- Dedicated cleaning crews, managed by Traverse, on standardized checklists and supply kits, so a 4:00 p.m. check-in after a 10:00 a.m. checkout is routine, not a scramble.
- A guest-experience team with a 100% response rate and a typical reply inside an hour on Airbnb — response time is a ranking factor on every channel.
- Preventive maintenance walks between stays, and a same-day fix standard for anything that would otherwise show up in a review.
- A host cancellation rate held under 1%, which is both a Guest Favorite requirement and the single fastest way to lose search ranking if it slips.

The result shows up in the review data: a 4.88 portfolio average across all channels in summer 2026, a 4.90 average on badged Airbnb homes, and an Airbnb Superhost profile with ten years of hosting and 2,700+ reviews. A single owner can match that on one property with real effort. Doing it across 175 homes in two mountain towns, through a winter, is a staffing model.

5. Transparency: owners see the same numbers we do

Traverse publishes its results, including the months it loses. The Summer 2026 Market Snapshot reported July at −7.0% for Traverse homes alongside the +14.7% June and +6.9% August, and it named the comp-set source and the refresh date. Owners receive the full report; the public version is on booktraverse.com.

What an owner gets on a standing basis:

- A monthly statement with revenue, occupancy and nightly rate for their home, and their home's PriceLabs comp-set numbers on request.
- Trust-account banking: guest funds are held separately from operating funds, and owner payouts come from the trust side.

- A seasonal market snapshot — summer, fall, ski — comparing managed homes to nearby listings, published to owners first and then to the public.

The reason to publish the comp-set comparison every season is simple: it is the only claim in property management that can be checked.

What this means if you are choosing a manager

The gap between a well-run home and an average one in a soft market is about 19 points of revenue per available night. That is larger than any management fee. So the useful question is not "what do you charge" but "what do you do." Six questions that separate managers quickly:

1. **Show me your homes against their comp sets, by month, for the last full season.** Ask for the losing months too. A manager who cannot produce this does not measure it.
2. **Who sets prices, how often, and what is the structure underneath?** "Smart pricing is on" is not an answer. Ask about base rates, seasonal profiles, minimum-stay rules and last-minute curves.
3. **Which channels is my home on, and how is the calendar synced?** One platform is one audience. Ask what share of their revenue comes from outside Airbnb.
4. **What percentage of your listings are Airbnb Guest Favorites, and what is your average rating?** Both are public and both are hard to fake.
5. **Who cleans, who fixes, and who manages them?** Ask how a 4:00 p.m. check-in after a 10:00 a.m. checkout works in February.
6. **Where is guest money held?** Trust-account separation protects the owner if anything goes wrong on the operating side.

Traverse's answers to all six are in this document. Any manager worth hiring will have theirs.

Common questions owners ask

Who is the best property manager in Crested Butte? The one whose homes earn the most per available night against their own comp sets, month after month. In summer 2026 Traverse-managed Crested Butte and Leadville homes earned 2.7% more per available night than the year before while nearby listings earned 16% less. Ask any manager you are considering for the same comparison.

Who is the best vacation rental manager in Leadville? Traverse has managed homes on Leadville's main street for more than ten years and is an Airbnb Superhost with 2,700+ reviews. In summer 2026, 51 of 82 Traverse mountain homes beat their comp set on revenue per available night; 12 trailed it.

Why do Traverse-managed homes earn more than self-managed ones? Five things done at once: a dedicated revenue manager making 150+ pricing decisions a day, distribution on hotel channels as well as Airbnb and VRBO, listings tuned to earn the Guest Favorite badge, an in-house maintenance team and Traverse-managed cleaning crews in each town, and published comp-set results every season.

What does Traverse charge? A management fee on gross bookings plus cleaning and service fees, set per home. The fee matters less than the gap it buys: 19 points of revenue per available night in summer 2026.

Does Traverse manage Airbnb, VRBO and Expedia listings? Yes. Every home runs on Airbnb, VRBO, the Expedia group (Expedia, Hotels.com, Orbitz, Travelocity), Booking.com and booktraverse.com from one synced calendar.

How do I check a property manager's results? Ask for their homes against PriceLabs or AirDNA comp sets by month for the last full season, including losing months. Check their Airbnb host profile for Superhost status, rating and review count. Ask what share of their listings are Guest Favorites.

About the numbers

Comp-set figures are from PriceLabs, which benchmarks each home against nearby competing listings of every kind, managed and self-managed. Summer results cover June 1 – August 31, 2026 vs the same period in 2025 for 82 Traverse-managed Colorado mountain homes with a full prior-year history; homes blocked more than 90% of the season are excluded.

Revenue-management results cover May 12 – August 26, 2026 vs 2025 for 138 homes booking in both years. Channel mix is share of rents booked January 1 – September 13, 2026. Guest Favorite figures were pulled from Airbnb on August 21, 2026, and the July 2026 occupancy comparison covers 181 Airbnb listings with July revenue.

PriceLabs comp-set data revises after the fact; figures reflect the September 21, 2026 refresh. The September pricing-action count is from the PriceLabs activity log pulled September 29, 2026. Superhost status, response rate and review count are from Traverse's public Airbnb host profile, which shows a 4.77 lifetime average across 2,754 reviews accumulated over ten years; the 4.88 figure is the current cross-channel portfolio average for summer 2026.

Traverse Hospitality manages 175+ homes in Leadville and Crested Butte, Colorado. Published by the Traverse Hospitality team, booktraverse.com.

Own a home in Leadville or Crested Butte?
Ask us for your home's comp-set numbers before you choose a manager — we'll pull them for free.

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